BERNSTEIN
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US Emerging Internet

US Emerging Internet: Can Consumer Internet stocks outperform in 2027? Three paths...



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Consumer Internet stocks — particularly aggregators — are battleground names as AI Agents (see Muse and Instinct) have stirred up discussions on the future of search, discovery, and online commerce. We like the risk/reward in our names at current multiples and feel the Street is overly negative given frictions in Agentic offerings, the trust barrier, and the typical rate at which consumer behavior evolves. But we can't predict the future either and will continue to follow the data. In our experience, these bear cases don't get shaken off that quickly, and it will likely take a few quarters (akin to the last time around with ChatGPT/Gemini). Longer-term, the trend probably is towards more conversational/agentic search, but not every end-market is the same and the clash of horizontal/vertical-specific agents could divide consumer behavior. We doubt the incumbents stand still.

Existential debates are not good for multiples. The median Consumer Internet stock in our basket is down -11% vs. the market up +14% YTD. Internet is now truly a GARP sector, with the median name at 22x GAAP 2027 P/E. Our specific coverage is at ~20x 2027 and 14.5x 2028 GAAP EPS. Rising yields and consumer concerns haven't helped. But through all the headlines, EPS revisions have been largely positive.

Can Consumer Internet stocks work in 2027? Perhaps what we need most is **rotation away from the AI trade and stabilization on rates**. We saw this in Q3 and again late last week on the OpenAI ARR kerfuffle. But in terms of what the companies can control...

Path #1: AI loser → AI neutral → AI winner. Considering the market we're in, the highest-upside path that has (thus far) been reserved for Hyperscalers and frontier model companies. As we saw with the SaaSpocalypse, changing the Street's view of your business model from AI loser to winner — or even proving that it is more defensible in the face of AI disruption — can drive a sharp re-rating in the group. This could come from horizontal agents hitting a wall on commerce or product launches from our coverage companies (the latter more compelling, but there needs to be a path to scaling it). UBER stands out given significant AV overhang — deploying driverless cars on the network in the US should improve the multiple on US Mobility. In Delivery, UBER/DASH/CART can highlight the uplift they are seeing from their vertical-specific agents around engagement/basket sizes.

Path #2: Revenue acceleration. Regardless of what technology paradigm we are in, revenue acceleration generally works in this sector. Beating on the top-line with stable growth or modest deceleration should hopefully be enough, but acceleration stories will be harder to refute. Wayfair is a stock in our coverage that could see growth improve further in 2027 (stabilization in the category, Rewards, Stores, ongoing improvement in the core offering), with cushion to beat Street numbers even if our model proves a touch optimistic.

Path #3: FCF upside. With big tech in a CapEx cycle, the Marketplace/App layer can offer relative FCF strength. In isolation, probably not enough given terminal value debates, but it helps to give investors something to play for with an incremental margin/FCF beat-and-raise cycle. DASH and EBAY are two stocks in our coverage where 2027 margins are the focal point. Even UBER has to settle debates around AV capital investments and M&A.

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BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

			9 Oct 2026		TTM	Adjusted EPS				Adjusted P/E (x)	
			Closing	Price	Rel.						
Ticker	Rating	Cur	Price	Target	Perf.	Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
DASH (DoorDash)	O	USD	196.50	270.00	(44.6)%	USD	5.08	5.70	8.03	38.7	34.5	24.5
EBAY (eBay)	M	USD	112.19	115.00	8.5%	USD	5.52	6.18	6.59	20.3	18.2	17.0
ETSY (Etsy)	M	USD	76.71	95.00	(10.7)%	USD	4.80	6.32	7.41	16.0	12.1	10.4
LYFT (Lyft)	M	USD	16.22	18.00	(33.7)%	USD	1.31	1.63	1.97	12.4	9.9	8.3
CART (Instacart)	O	USD	47.76	60.00	6.2%	USD	3.42	4.18	4.90	14.0	11.4	9.7
UBER (Uber)	O	USD	71.51	95.00	(41.5)%	USD	2.45	3.34	4.36	29.1	21.4	16.4
W (Wayfair)	O	USD	105.74	125.00	18.1%	USD	2.60	3.10	4.50	40.7	34.1	23.5
ZG (Zillow)	M	USD	29.87	38.00	(72.2)%	USD	1.65	2.25	2.89	18.1	13.3	10.3
SPX			7,811.54									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

We rate DASH, UBER, CART, and W Outperform. We rate the rest of our coverage Market-Perform.

DETAILS

TECH IS MOVING FAST, AND THE STOCKS ARE MOVING FASTER

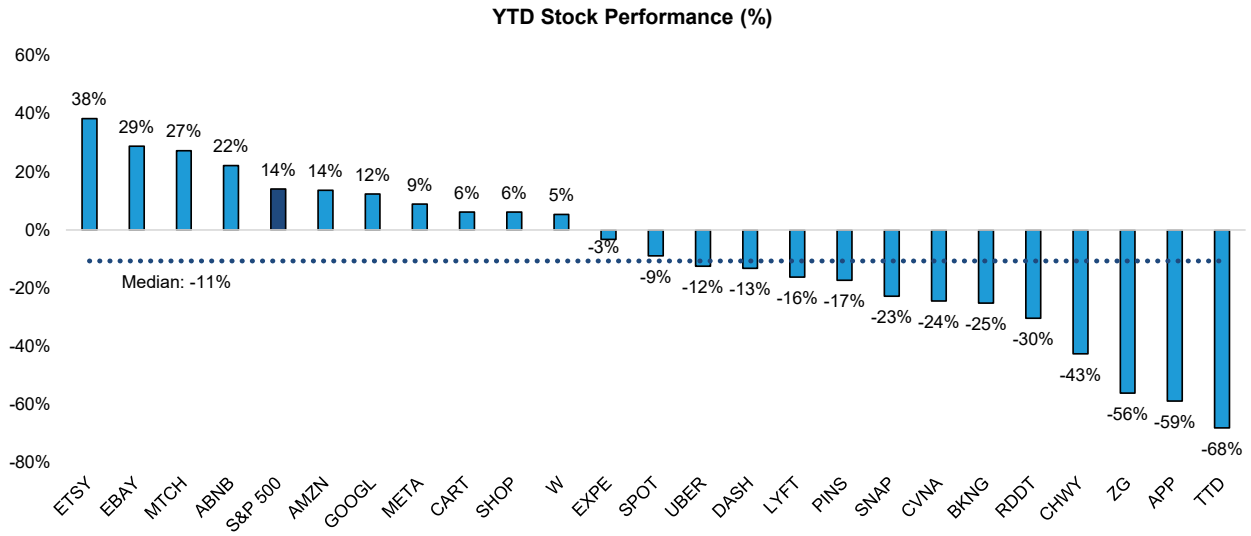
While there are still few months to go, it's been a difficult YTD backdrop for Consumer Internet stocks. The median name is down -11% relative to the S&P500 being up 14%. When technology is moving this quickly, investors are forced to rethink their prior assumptions around moats, competitive dynamics, and where value accrues across the digital economy. 2026 has been the year of several terminal value debates across our coverage, which is never great for multiples. Increased concerns around the consumer/inflation, along with higher oil prices and interest rates haven't helped either.

AI remains the dominant theme in markets, and the online aggregators we cover are largely seen as challenged business models if consumer Agents scale. We think these fears are likely being overdone right now, and see encouraging buying opportunities across our space. Nonetheless, we'll be watching the data around adoption, retention, and engagement like everyone else.

Certainly, the AI narrative is hard to shrug off until we have clearer data points to anchor to. In the long-run, we can see how/why Agentic and conversational search could proliferate, but the clash between horizontal and vertical-specific agents is yet to fully play out. If there is one truism we have internalized covering the sector it's that you cannot fight the consumer — ultimately, user behavior will determine which channels prevail. Becoming the 'aggregator of aggregators' is an enticing prize, but there are real world complexities around these transactions that come into play too.

Beyond Agentic Commerce dynamics, our coverage on Rideshare has also been affected by competitive risks from Autonomous Vehicles — a clear commercial breakthrough for "Physical AI". AVs are a small component of the US rideshare market today (~1%), but growing quickly and likely to become a core driver of urban mobility services in the long-run. AV fleets are reaching an inflection point, led by Waymo, and we will likely go from a few thousand cars to tens of thousands in the coming years. Much like Agentic, the market has converged upon a view that the incumbent rideshare networks will get disrupted. Physical AI is in the early stages. Autonomy across delivery, drones, and robotics will become more relevant in the years to come.

EXHIBIT 1: **Minefields everywhere this year.**



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

US INTERNET IS CHEAP AND OUT OF FAVOR

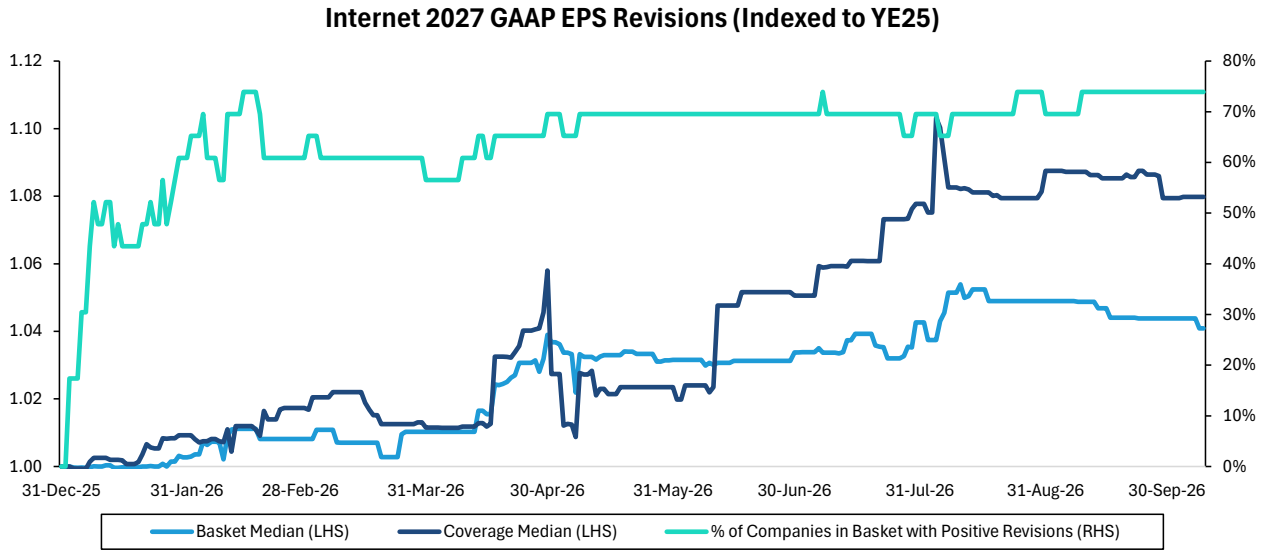
For anyone who has followed the space for a while, the multiples shown in Exhibit 2 are quite incredible to see. Not only has the basket become GAAP profitable, but the median GAAP P/E multiple in the group has compressed to 22x 2027 EPS. Fast-forward to 2028, and the basket is trading at 18x Street EPS. Our US Emerging Internet coverage specifically is now at ~20x 2027 and 14.5x 2028 GAAP EPS. And that incorporates a couple of high-multiple stocks in DASH and W that are skewing the median higher. UBER's position on this list, at the very low-end of our coverage, is surprising and speaks to how one-sided the debate has gotten on AVs — no upside scenarios being priced in. All while EPS growth remains robust.

EXHIBIT 2: **Internet is now a true GARP sector...and on its way to Value land?**

Stack ranking Internet Stocks on Forward GAAP P/E Ratio		
Ticker	**2027 GAAP P/E**	**2028 GAAP P/E**
MTCH	12.6x	10.7x
EXPE	12.6x	10.8x
BKNG	13.2x	11.2x
APP	14.0x	11.2x
UBER	15.9x	12.7x
CART	16.2x	14.0x
ETSY	16.8x	14.7x
CHWY	17.0x	14.8x
LYFT	17.7x	14.2x
S&P 500	**18.6x**	**16.1x**
META	21.1x	18.3x
ZG	21.7x	14.4x
EBAY	22.0x	19.0x
RDDT	22.1x	17.7x
GOOGL	23.2x	19.4x
AMZN	24.4x	18.6x
ABNB	26.6x	22.6x
PINS	27.2x	19.6x
CVNA	28.0x	22.0x
SPOT	35.6x	28.7x
DASH	42.5x	28.1x
SNAP	47.9x	25.1x
TTD	50.2x	31.5x
W	54.6x	35.1x
SHOP	80.0x	55.8x
Median	**22.1x**	**18.4x**
US Emerging Internet Median	**19.7x**	**14.5x**
Coverage Median ex-DASH/W	**17.2x**	**14.3x**

Based on consensus GAAP EPS estimates for calendar 2027 and 2028.
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 3: **Apart from a few names, estimate revisions have not been the problem. Estimates are up +4% for the broader Internet basket and +8% for our coverage.**



Excludes SNAP which had negative EPS expectations to start the year and skews the median given starting point of index. But revisions have been positive here as well.
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

HOW DO YOU SHAKE OFF THE BEAR CASE?

It's hard to imagine there's a one-size-fits-all answer to this question given how disparate Consumer Internet is as a sector — many end-markets, a variety of business models, different degrees of AI risk/opportunity. Perhaps the one overarching (and most impactful?) tailwind that could trump all would be rotation away from the AI trade, which contributed to a (brief) rebound in these names through Q3. We got another taste of this late last week as the confusion around OpenAI's ARR figure drove better price action in the 'non-AI' names, ours included. And that makes the pending IPOs from the frontier labs very interesting, in part because of the ripple effect they will have on the broader market and our sector depending on how they are received.

In terms of variables the company's can control...

- **Path #1: AI loser → AI neutral → AI winner.** Considering the market we're in, the highest-upside path that has (thus far) been reserved for Hyperscalers and frontier model companies. Changing the Street's view of your business model from AI loser to winner — or even proving that it is more defensible in the face of AI disruption — can drive a sharp re-rating in the group. We saw it with the SaaSpocalypse. This could come from horizontal agents hitting a wall on adoption around commerce (akin to ChatGPT/Gemini the first go around), but that's not within the companies' control and only kicks the can down the road. Ideally, product launches put our names at the forefront of where tech and consumer behavior is going and reinforce the value of the networks/marketplaces these companies have built.

  - **UBER** has the most to gain from a perception shift on AVs. At 16x 2027 and 13x 2028 GAAP EPS, it is *the cheapest* name in our coverage, despite strong fundamentals. The market is clearly bearish on the prospect of AVs for the Mobility business and we acknowledge the risk of Waymo and Tesla scaling in the years to come. However, the company is also not getting any credit around its US Mobility business anymore and deploying driverless cars on the network in the US over the next 6-12 months should improve the Street's view of the terminal value in Mobility. That data point is arguably all you need to shift the narrative in a better direction and regain a few turns on the multiple. Much of our commentary below on DASH applies to UBER's Delivery business too, albeit it's dependent on a partner network for autonomy.

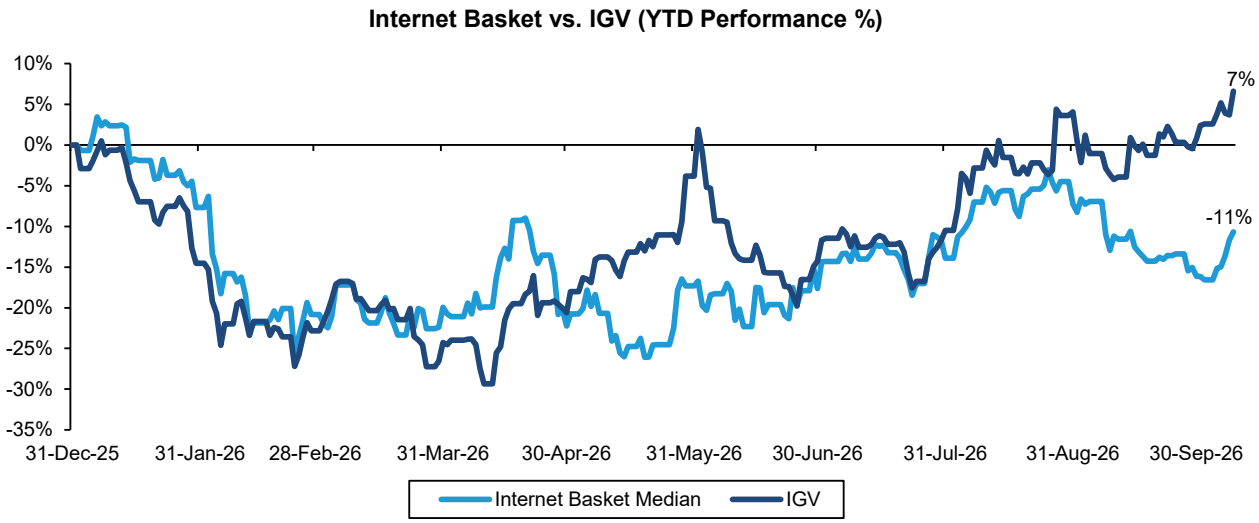
  - Sentiment on **DASH** is not as dire, but Delivery stocks have traded lower on Agentic Commerce concerns — the risks being disintermediation and/or lower margins (i.e., higher CAC, less ad revenue) if search & discovery is outsourced to Agents. Our rebuttal to the bear case is: (1) consumer behavior has to shift first; (2) in a duopoly market with membership lock-in and scaled on-demand logistics, fees can be adjusted to absorb any headwinds to advertising revenue; and (3) these platforms add value in logistics and real-time inventory insight which is needed for Agentic too (particularly

Grocery & Retail). DoorDash Forward highlighted how the company is leaning in via "Ask DoorDash", "Text DoorDash" and autonomous delivery solutions (both drones and delivery robots) — any concrete data points on the impact these efforts are having on order frequency, customer retention rates, and basket building would position DASH more positively.

- **Path #2: Revenue acceleration.** Somewhat irrespective of the tech paradigm, accelerating growth is usually rewarded in this sector. It's hard to argue with positive revision stories that are led by the top-line, particularly if the underlying driver of the acceleration is volume (i.e., users and orders). If revenue acceleration is coupled with Path #1 via a higher converting search and discovery flow or incremental product (like AI-assisted search), even better. We expect AI/ML advancements to contribute to better onsite experiences for the marketplaces we cover. We believe **Wayfair** is a way to play this theme in our space — we see a path for ~HSD revenue growth to improve to ~10% next year on category stabilization (macro permitting), a Rewards program, physical store build out, and ongoing improvements in the core offering. Given where Internet multiples have compressed to, GMV upside — even if there is deceleration — should be rewarded, in our view. US eCommerce will be interesting to watch on this front considering 2026 strength on a YTD basis.

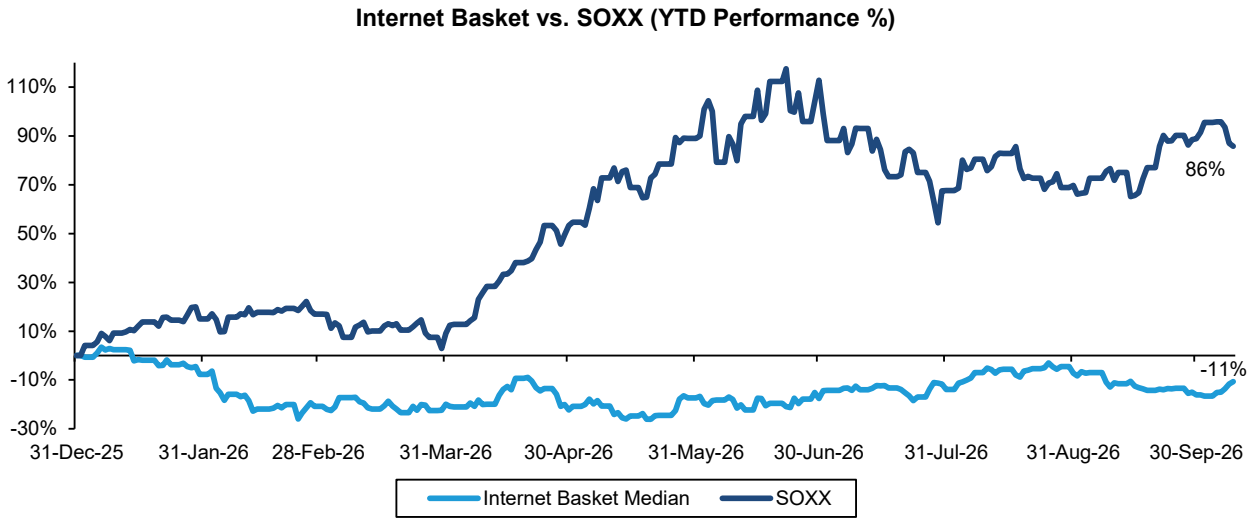
- **Path #3: FCF and Margin upside.** With CapEx ramping for the Hyperscalers/frontier model companies, offering margin and FCF upside can be a point of differentiation for other names in the sector. In isolation, it's probably not enough if the market is debating terminal values, but giving investors something to play for with an incremental margin/FCF beat-and-raise cycle can help. Coupled with an improving narrative on Path #1, it can be effective. DASH and EBAY are two stocks in our coverage where 2027 margins are the focal point of the investor debate and better-than-expected EBIT would be received well. Even UBER has to settle fears around AV capital investment and M&A philosophy.

EXHIBIT 4: **Internet was trading like Software for much of the year...but hasn't had the same momentum exiting Q3 given Agentic and consumer concerns.**



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 5: **There have been much better returns elsewhere in tech. Consumer Internet needs rotation away from the AI trade to work better.**



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 6: **Near-term, our space will likely trade on Consumer AI data points. Stable Muse downloads...**

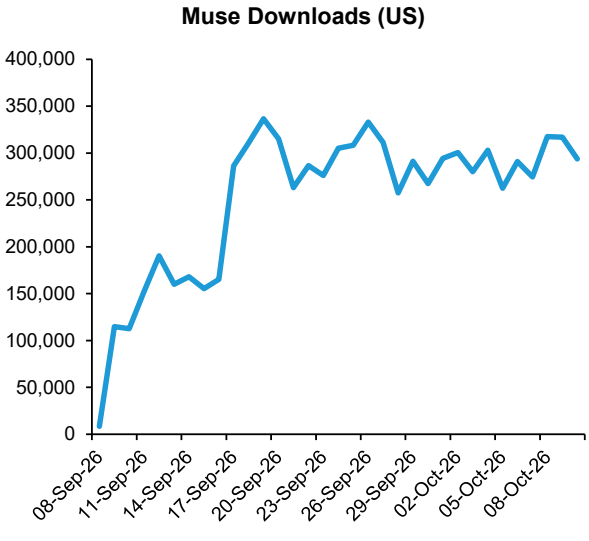
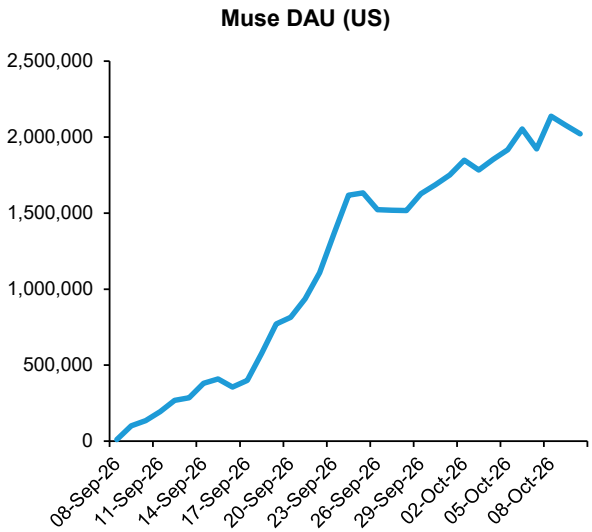
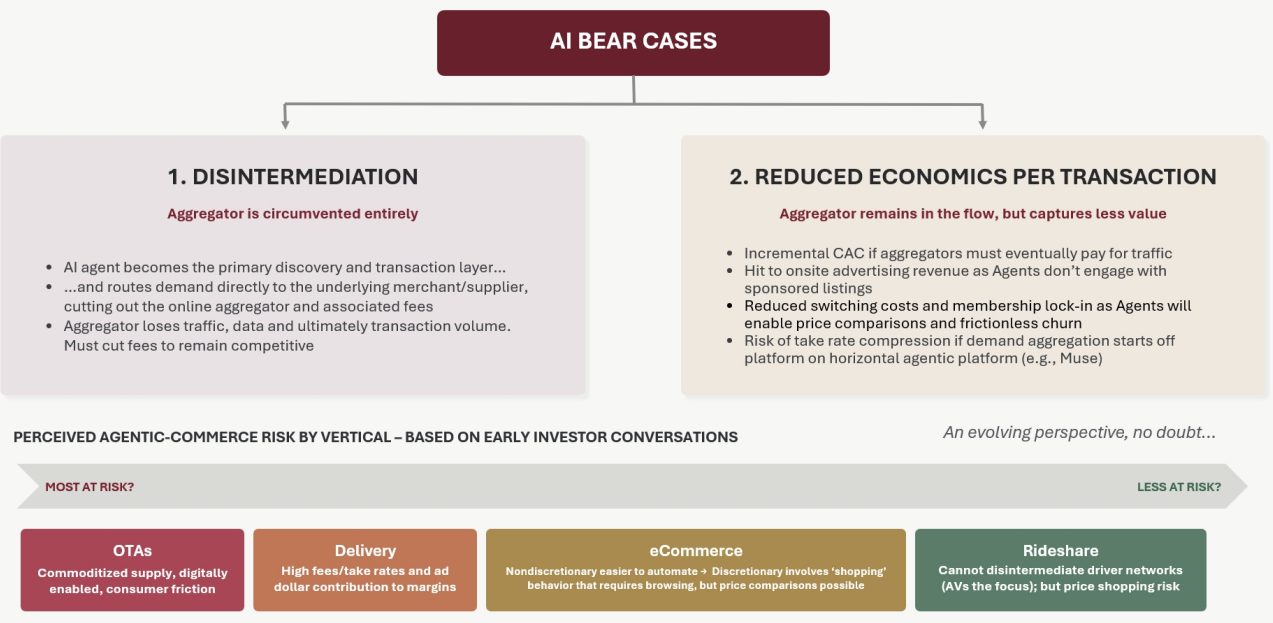


EXHIBIT 7: **...and US DAU count that shot up to ~2M very quickly, per third-party estimates. The shape of this curve matters.**



Source: SensorTower, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 8: **Agentic bear cases for marketplaces, in a nutshell.**



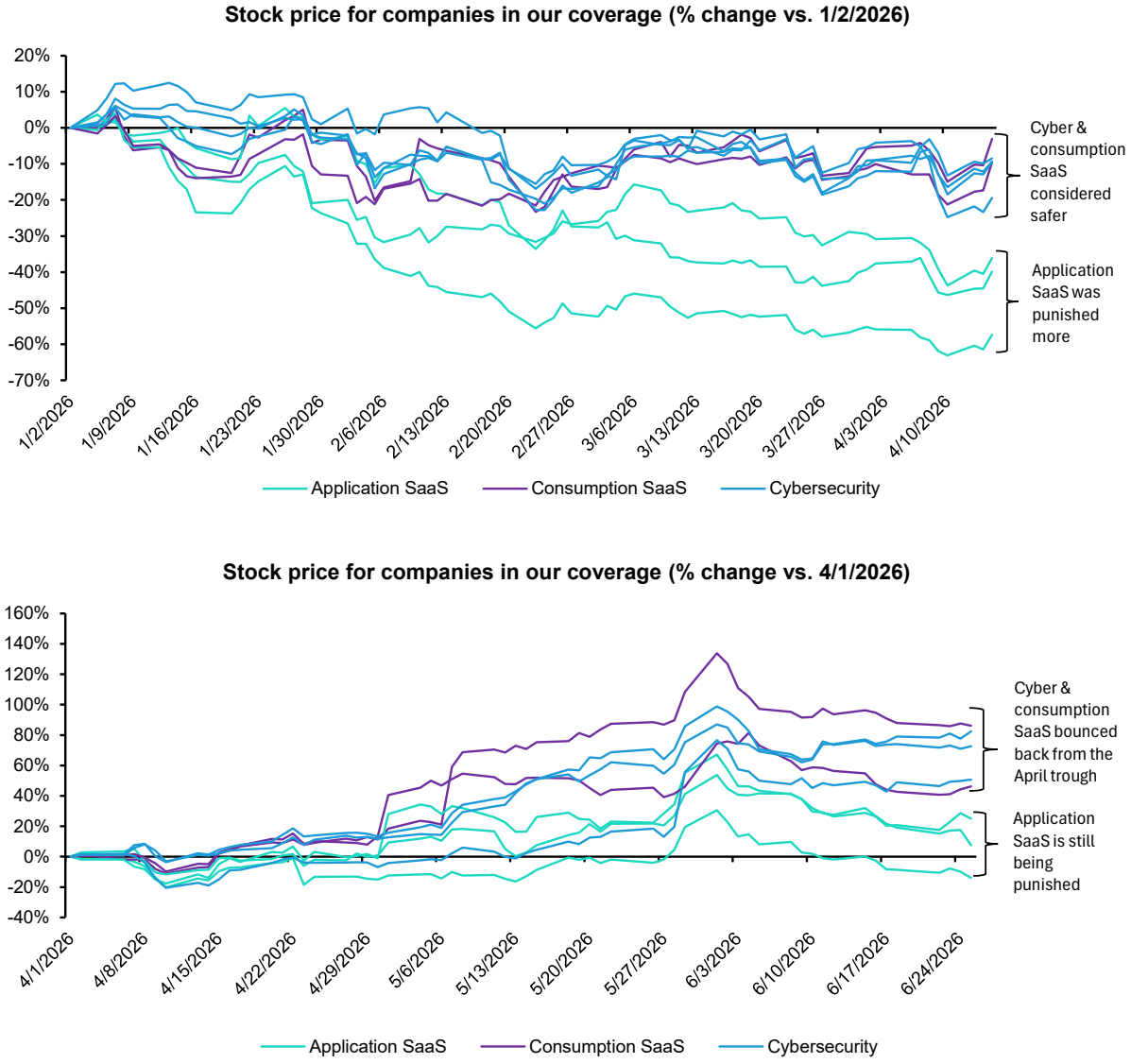
Source: Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 9: **How do you disprove the bear case? Time, fundamentals, and a narrative shift...**



Source: Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 10: **The current dialogue in Consumer Internet reminds us of the SaaSpocalypse, which reversed sharply this summer in certain subsectors of Software. If this is the right analogy for our space, the question now becomes which stocks and subsectors of Internet will be perceived as AI defensive/beneficiaries.**



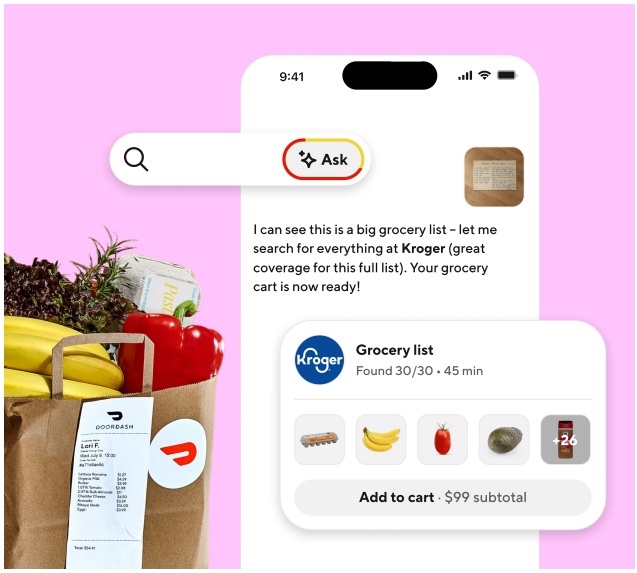
Source: Bernstein US SMID-Cap Software team

EXHIBIT 11: **To change perception around its positioning in the AV race, UBER and its partner network need to hit key launch and driverless milestones next year, particularly in the US market.**



Though original launch timing indicated earlier, we expect Momenta and May Mobility launches in 2027.
Source: Company reports, press reports, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 12: **The new "Ask DoorDash" and "Text DoorDash" features are bringing conversational/AI-enbaled commerce to the platform. UBER and CART have similar offerings as well…**



Source: Company reports

EXHIBIT 13: **…and DASH is investing behind autonomy with Dot (delivery robots) and DoorDash Air (drones) that will likely become a bigger feature on the marketplace over the next several years.**



Source: Company reports

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- Underperform (UP): The total return of the preferred instrument is expected to underperform preferred securities of other issuers operating in similar sectors or rating categories over the next six months.

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